that we could do it. The penultimate game that season, at home to Nottingham Forest, was the night I realized we actually would. We beat Forest 5–0. I still remember the two goals I scored. Eric hit a volley which skewed off target and I headed in as the ball came across me. Then, I received a ball just inside the area which I turned on and hit under the keeper. In the end, we had to win our final game at Middlesbrough to be absolutely sure of the title, but everyone—players and supporters—at Old Trafford that night just knew we were going to be champions.

We'd just kept coming in for training, turning up for games and were all on the kind of high which has you half-expecting things to go wrong at any minute. In the United first team? Winning the Premiership? There had to be a catch. But there wasn't. Instead, it got better and better. We weren't just on our way to winning the League. How many FA Cup Finals had I been to at Wembley with Dad? Every time, both of us imagining what it would be like for me to play in one? And now, March 1996, here were United at Villa Park for a semi-final against Chelsea, who had Mark Hughes in their side. I didn't know if I'd ever have a better chance.

I couldn't wait, although I promised myself I'd stay well out of Sparky's way when the day came. I'm really friendly with Mark now. We see quite a lot of him, his wife Gill and their three children, who are the nicest, politest kids you'll ever meet. I always used to say to Victoria that they were how I hoped our children would be. I knew back then, though, that it didn't matter how well I knew Mark or how close we were off the field; on it—if he had to—he'd smash me as soon as he'd smash anybody else. He was one of those players whose character changes when they go out to play. Mark Hughes would fight for the ball, and fight anyone for it, all day long, which is why supporters and team-mates loved him like they did. I've seen games where he didn't just bully the center-half he was playing against, he'd bully the entire opposing team.

Chelsea took the lead on the afternoon, Ruud Gullit scoring with a header. Then Andy Cole equalized for us. Well into the second half, one of their defenders, Craig Burley, misplaced a pass. Steve Bruce, who was on the bench, shouted: 'Go on, Becks!' As the ball came towards me, I took a touch and it bounced away a bit off my shin. That took me wider of the goal than I would have wanted. But the keeper came out—we actually caught each other's eyes for a split second—and I slotted it past him into the corner. I ran off to celebrate: I jumped up in the air, threw my fist up and, I swear, at that moment I felt like I could have reached out to touch the roof of the stand, like I could have hung there till the final whistle went. I remember being